

The Weekly Digest

Issue Date: 2026-04-18

THE WORLD THIS WEEK

Politics

America and Iran maintained a shaky ceasefire.

Peace negotiations between America and Iran in Pakistan ended without a deal, but both sides are preparing for another round of discussions. Donald Trump claimed the war is "close to over," while America asserted its blockade of the Strait of Hormuz was successful in targeting Iranian shipping.

Hopes for peace were also given a boost when Israel and Lebanon held their first official direct talks.

Ambassadors from Israel and Lebanon met in

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Washington for the first direct talks in decades, agreeing to launch negotiations. The Israeli ambassador spoke of a shared goal to liberate Lebanon from Hizbullah, despite Hizbullah's threats of a coup against the Lebanese government if it attempts this. Meanwhile, Israel's ground assault in southern Lebanon and Hizbullah's rocket attacks on Israel continued.

Cyril Ramaphosa, South Africa's president, appointed Roelf Meyer as the country's new ambassador to America.

South Africa's President Cyril Ramaphosa appointed Roelf Meyer as the new ambassador to America, replacing an ambassador expelled for accusing Donald Trump of "white victimhood." Meyer has a history as a key negotiator in ending apartheid and a co-founder of the United Democratic Movement.

The Australian government announced a rise in defence

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spending.

Australia's government announced an increase in defense spending from 2% to 3% of GDP by 2033. The defense minister cited the country facing its "most complex and threatening strategic circumstances" since the second world war.

The head of the International Atomic Energy Agency warned that North Korea has made "very serious" advances in its nuclear-weapons programme.

The IAEA head warned of North Korea's "very serious" advances in its nuclear weapons program, including a probable new uranium-enrichment facility. The regime is believed to possess several dozen nuclear warheads.

Around 250 people were missing after a boat capsized in the Andaman Sea.

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A boat carrying Rohingya refugees and Bangladeshis from Teknaf, Bangladesh, to Malaysia capsized in the Andaman Sea, leaving approximately 250 people missing.

George Robertson, a former NATO secretary-general and former British defence secretary, levelled a scathing critique at current defence policy.

Lord Robertson, who drafted Britain's latest strategic defense review, issued a scathing critique of current defense policy, stating Britain is in "peril" due to the government's "corrosive complacency." He blamed the Treasury for failing to fund the review's recommendations, concluding that the country is underprepared, underinsured, under attack, and unsafe, citing recent Russian activity near British undersea infrastructure.

In Canada the Liberal Party secured a small majority in

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the House of Commons.

The Liberal Party gained a small majority in the House of Commons after winning three special constituency elections, moving from a minority government. Prime Minister Mark Carney is credited with attracting disaffected opposition members, leading to four Conservatives joining the Liberals recently.

Keiko Fujimori advanced to the second round of Peru's presidential election.

Keiko Fujimori advanced to the second round of Peru's presidential election, marking her fourth attempt for the office. She is the daughter of Alberto Fujimori, a former president convicted of ordering a death squad.

At least 15 people were killed in another wave of drone attacks by Russia on Ukraine.

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Russia launched another wave of drone attacks on Ukraine, including Kyiv, killing at least 15 people. Conversely, Ukraine's army, using unmanned ground systems and drones for the first time, captured a Russian position without casualties, according to President Volodymyr Zelensky, who noted the extensive use of ground robotic systems on the front line this year.

The centrist Tisza party won around two-thirds of the seats in Hungary's election.

Hungary's centrist Tisza party won approximately two-thirds of parliamentary seats, ousting Viktor Orban and his populist-right Fidesz party after 16 years. Incoming prime minister Peter Magyar prioritized improving EU relations, spoke with European Commission President Ursula von der Leyen, and suggested reversing Hungary's block on a \$90bn EU loan to Ukraine. The Kremlin expressed a desire for "pragmatic dialogue" with the new Hungarian

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government.

Following several days of protests the government of Ireland announced a support package to help people affected by the spike in fuel costs.

Ireland's government announced a support package to address rising fuel costs after days of protests, during which demonstrators blocked highways and caused traffic disruptions with lorries and tractors.

A pupil at a school in south-east Turkey shot and killed at least nine people.

A pupil at a school in south-east Turkey shot and killed at least nine people, an incident following another school shooting the previous day where a former pupil wounded 16 before killing himself.

Pedro Sánchez, the Socialist prime minister of Spain,

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launched a scheme to offer permanent residency to half a million illegal migrants.

Spanish Prime Minister Pedro Sánchez launched a scheme to grant permanent residency to half a million illegal migrants who have lived in Spain for five months and have no criminal record. Separately, his wife, Begoña Gómez, was charged with corruption, which she denies, claiming the allegations are politically motivated.

The prime minister of Italy, Giorgia Meloni, said her administration had suspended the renewal of its defence co-operation agreement with Israel.

Italy's Prime Minister Giorgia Meloni announced the suspension of its defense co-operation agreement renewal with Israel, citing "the current situation." This decision marks a shift for Italy's conservative government, previously a reliable Israeli ally, and follows its refusal to allow America to use a Sicilian air

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base for operations against Iran.

Ms Meloni's refusal to support America's war with Iran has angered Mr Trump.

Donald Trump expressed disappointment with Italian Prime Minister Giorgia Meloni for not supporting America's war with Iran, stating he thought she was "brave, but I was wrong." Meloni also criticized Trump's harsh comments about Pope Leo XIV, who took a strong stand against the Iran war, asserting that the pontiff's call for peace was "right and normal."

Business

The IMF lowered its forecast of global growth, projecting the world economy to expand by 3.1% this year, down from the 3.3% it estimated in January.

The IMF reduced its global growth forecast for 2026 to 3.1% from 3.3%, largely due to the Iran conflict, which

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shaved half a percentage point off most major economies, including Britain's (now 0.8%). The fund noted that without the war, forecasts would have been upgraded, indicating the conflict's true economic cost is greater than current projections. The most pronounced impact is on commodity-importing emerging-market and developing economies.

America's annual inflation rate surged to 3.3% in March from 2.4% in February.

America's annual inflation rate climbed to 3.3% in March from 2.4% in February, driven by a 10.9% jump in energy prices from the previous month. Fuel-oil prices increased by 30.7%, and regular petrol remains above \$4 a gallon, up from \$3.17 a year ago. These figures highlight significant cost pressures on consumers.

Oil trading stayed volatile, with Brent crude fetching between \$95 and \$100 a barrel.

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Oil trading remained volatile, with Brent crude fluctuating between \$95 and \$100 a barrel, as the International Energy Agency labeled the Iran conflict the "most severe oil-supply shock in history." The IEA now forecasts a global oil demand decline of 80,000 barrels a day in 2026, a sharp reversal from its prior forecast of 640,000 barrels a day growth. This projection assumes a resumption of regular Middle East oil and gas deliveries by mid-year.

Not everyone is suffering because of the war.

Despite the global economic toll of the war, BP reported an "exceptional" quarter for its oil-trading desk due to soaring prices and customers scrambling for supplies. Other oil companies' upcoming earnings reports will balance these gains from higher prices against any production losses incurred during the conflict.

America's big banks also said their trading desks had

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done well in the first quarter, helped by volatility in equity markets.

America's major banks reported strong performance from their trading desks in the first quarter, benefiting from equity market volatility. JPMorgan Chase saw a 13% rise in net profit to \$16.5bn year-on-year, while Citigroup recorded its highest revenue in a decade at \$24.6bn, boosting its profit by 42% to \$5.8bn. Goldman Sachs also achieved a 19% profit increase to \$5.6bn, largely driven by its equity traders.

Tech stocks resumed their ascent.

Tech stocks have resumed their upward trajectory, with Oracle's share price increasing over 20% in five days and Nvidia's by 10%. Intel's stock is up 45% since April 1st, following a partnership announcement with Elon Musk's Terafab project. The NASDAQ Composite achieved its longest winning streak since 2023, and the S&P 500

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reached a new record high.

China's GDP grew by 5% in the first quarter, year on year, a robust performance that beat analysts' expectations.

China's GDP expanded by 5% in the first quarter year-on-year, surpassing analyst expectations with a robust performance. However, the government has cautioned that the economy is expected to suffer a hit from the Iran war in the second quarter.

Donald Trump said he would remove Jerome Powell from the Federal Reserve's board of governors if he stays on beyond the end of his term as chairman, which is May 15th.

Donald Trump announced his intention to remove Jerome Powell from the Federal Reserve's board of governors if he remains beyond his chairmanship term,

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expiring May 15th. This follows a judge's dismissal of Justice Department subpoenas in an investigation into Mr. Powell regarding alleged misleading of Congress about the Fed's refurbishment. The Senate Banking Committee is scheduled to hold a confirmation hearing for Kevin Warsh, Mr. Powell's replacement, on April 21st.

A jury found that Live Nation, the owner of Ticketmaster, had illegally tried to thwart competition in the market for live events.

A jury found Live Nation, Ticketmaster's owner, guilty of illegally suppressing competition in the live events market. The Department of Justice initiated the case in 2024 and reached a settlement with the company soon after the trial began in March, while other parties continued their claims. The judge is now set to determine the penalty.

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Amazon struck a deal to buy Globalstar, which operates a low-orbit satellite constellation, for \$11.6bn.

Amazon has agreed to acquire Globalstar, a low-orbit satellite constellation operator, for \$11.6bn. This acquisition is a strategic move to compete with Elon Musk's Starlink, granting Amazon crucial radiowave spectrum rights for future mobile connectivity. The company is actively launching more satellites to bolster its internet services for airlines like JetBlue and Delta Air Lines.

The crew of NASA's Artemis II mission returned safely to Earth.

The NASA Artemis II mission crew successfully returned to Earth, splashing down in the Pacific Ocean off San Diego. The capsule endured a high-speed re-entry. NASA Administrator Jared Isaacman promised more Moon missions, with the goal of landing in 2028

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and establishing a lunar base.

The boss goes AI

Meta is reportedly developing an animated AI version of Mark Zuckerberg to interact with employees, trained using his image, voice, and mannerisms. This AI is intended to discuss staff problems, performance, and possibly even job cuts.

The weekly cartoon

The weekly cartoon depicts themes related to Israel and Lebanon, specifically the complex situation surrounding Hizbullah and the duration of Israel's involvement in Lebanon. It alludes to the potential for a "quagmire" without a clear strategic resolution.

LEADERS

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America wakes up to AI's dangerous power

America's previous laissez-faire stance on artificial intelligence is ending, prompted by national security threats and growing public anxiety, especially after Anthropic's Claude Mythos demonstrated alarming cyber capabilities. The government faces a critical challenge to rapidly implement a control scheme, balancing economic growth from AI with the imperative to prevent malevolent use. While history suggests powerful industries eventually face regulation, AI's rapid evolution and global nature make traditional governmental tools daunting, demanding urgent, comprehensive thinking across safety, economic, and social policy.

How to end the war in Iran

To end the futile war, America and Iran must translate their shaky ceasefire into a lasting peace by reopening

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the Strait of Hormuz and resolving Iran's nuclear program. This demands significant compromise and trust-building from both sides, especially from Donald Trump. America's new blockade provides leverage through Iran's dire economic state, but its success is uncertain as Iran may endure it, leading to a surge in American petrol prices. A credible deal requires international monitoring of Iran's nuclear activities, including uranium enrichment, to prevent a dash for a bomb, but triumph over the fighting is unlikely, necessitating rebuilding Gulf security infrastructure.

America will come to regret its war on taxes

America is embroiled in a bipartisan tax-cutting frenzy, with both Republicans and Democrats advocating for policies that would exempt large segments of the population from federal income taxes, relying on tariffs or taxes on the wealthy to fund the state. This approach is fiscally irresponsible, given record budget deficits, and could lead to a bond-market reckoning. Politically, tax

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giveaways are proving ineffective in securing lasting popularity or addressing voter anxieties, which stem from high nominal prices rather than declining purchasing power. Furthermore, removing many Americans from the tax base risks deepening political dysfunction by severing the connection between citizens and efficient government, making a mature discussion about fiscal choices unattainable.

Peter Magyar's victory will keep Hungary in the spotlight

Peter Magyar's triumphant centrist Tisza party victory in Hungary, which ousted Viktor Orban after 16 years, offers a crucial test case for reversing democratic decay. Magyar's success stemmed from voter frustration with corruption and economic stagnation, not abstract tyranny, and represented a clear rejection of foreign interference. He now faces the formidable task of dismantling Orban's entrenched state controls, reforming the constitution, and restoring the rule of law to unlock

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billions in withheld EU funds. His leadership will be closely watched by liberals globally, hoping he can successfully rebuild Hungary's institutions and improve its standing within the EU.

Donald Trump has made Venezuela a better place

Donald Trump's intervention in Venezuela, leading to Nicolás Maduro's capture, has undeniably improved the country, fostering open political meetings and easing repression, yet Mr. Trump misinterprets this incomplete success as a model for regime change. Venezuela's transformation is limited, with democracy still unsecured and foreign investment deterred by legal uncertainty and a large number of political prisoners. Moreover, Trump's transactional methods are not easily replicable in ideologically driven regimes like Iran's, where shared beliefs can prevent fracturing, making his "perfect scenario" claim for other conflicts fundamentally flawed.

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The impending global food shock is preventable

The war in the Gulf is on the verge of causing a "slow-motion calamity," threatening an additional 45m people with hunger if the Strait of Hormuz remains closed and exacerbates existing food insecurity. The region is crucial for fertiliser, natural gas, and oil supplies, and disruptions will severely impact crop yields and drive up global food prices, compounded by an impending powerful El Niño. While solutions exist?Iran allowing fertiliser passage, America not blockading urea, redirecting biofuels, and rich countries providing food aid?a "selfish mood" among nations suggests this preventable disaster will tragically unfold.

LETTERS

Does the European Convention on Human

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Rights need reforming?

Readers offer diverse views on reforming the European Convention on Human Rights, particularly concerning the Chisinau political declaration. Michael O'Flaherty, Commissioner for Human Rights, argues that allowing member states to interpret protections against torture and for family life challenges judicial independence and threatens the inherent nature of human rights. Other correspondents discuss the shortcomings of Britain's post-Brexit farming policy, the historical influence of Ovid on Bob Dylan, the environmental impact of Donald Trump's ballroom project, and the nostalgic term "netizen."

BY INVITATION

Welcome to the world of machine audiences

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Artificial intelligence is instigating a profound demand-side transformation in the information economy, ushering in the age of "machine audiences" that ask questions and synthesize knowledge at an unprecedented scale. This shift, akin to past information revolutions, expands both machine and human demand by addressing highly specific needs and lowering cognitive barriers to complex information. However, traditional knowledge producers are ill-prepared for this new paradigm, as the value of this expanded market is increasingly captured by AI systems that control the user relationship and demand signal. This dynamic risks degrading the knowledge base and necessitates new models for attribution, compensation, and the establishment of common ground to prevent the dissolution of shared realities.

BRIEFING

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Venezuela is not the triumph Donald Trump claims, but it's improving

Venezuela has seen significant improvements since Nicolás Maduro's capture by American special forces, with opposition movements operating openly and hopes for economic growth rising, though Donald Trump's claims of complete success are overstated. While repression has eased and investor interest has surged, widespread investments remain cautious due to historical gouging and the lack of secure democracy. High inflation persists, and the path to genuine elections is murky, with the current regime maintaining control and tolerating liberalization only to buy time. Opposition leader María Corina Machado is determined to press for elections, potentially through street protests, despite American pressure to delay.

UNITED STATES

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A tax revolt is under way in America

A bipartisan "tax-cutting mania" is sweeping America, with both Republicans and Democrats advocating policies that would significantly reduce or eliminate federal income taxes for many citizens. This trend, exemplified by Donald Trump's "Big, Beautiful Bill" and proposals from Democratic senators like Cory Booker and Chris Van Hollen, risks exacerbating record budget deficits. The widespread public discontent with the fairness of the tax system, at a 30-year low, drives this political impulse, but critics warn that detaching large portions of the electorate from tax contributions could deepen political dysfunction and prevent necessary fiscal conversations.

Pete Hegseth's Pentagon is a lethality-maxxing wasps' nest

America's armed forces, despite their displayed prowess in the Iran air campaign, are internally roiled by

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infighting and politicization under Secretary of War Pete Hegseth. Mr. Hegseth has conducted an unprecedented purge of at least 21 senior generals, often for unclear reasons, in an apparent effort to instill an "anti-woke warrior ethos" and has been criticized for prioritizing culture wars over strategic matters. Critics warn that his vindictive actions, including replacing experienced officers with less qualified but politically aligned figures, could undermine the military's nonpartisan culture and inflict lasting damage beyond the current conflict.

The Hudson is now so clean that everyone can eat from it

For the first time in 50 years, some fish caught in the Lower Hudson River are safe for general consumption, marking a remarkable ecological recovery for what was once one of the country's largest Superfund sites. This environmental turnaround is largely due to General Electric's \$1.7bn, six-year cleanup effort to remove polychlorinated biphenyls (PCBs) from a 200-mile

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stretch of the river. While the Hudson is significantly cleaner and mostly safe for swimming, certain fish species and areas further north still carry warnings, underscoring the ongoing nature of its restoration.

POTUS v the Pope

President Donald Trump publicly attacked Pope Leo XIV, calling him "WEAK" and "terrible" at diplomacy, after the pontiff criticized Trump's threat to obliterate Iranian civilization. This unprecedented presidential broadside against the head of the Catholic Church baffled the Vatican and united most American Catholics in disapproval. Vice-President J.D. Vance, a Catholic convert, also suggested the Pope stay out of international affairs. The confrontation risks transforming Pope Leo XIV, in the eyes of many, from a spiritual leader into a global anti-Trump figure.

The big business of survival bunkers

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"Prepping" has moved into the mainstream, with approximately 20 million Americans now preparing for various emergencies, fueling a booming market for survival bunkers. Companies like Atlas Survival Shelters and Vivos are experiencing surging demand, offering bomb and fallout shelters ranging from \$25,000 to \$10m, particularly spurred by the war with Iran. These firms cater to a wide clientele, including DIY enthusiasts and those seeking communal survival communities, despite facing contemporary challenges such as tariffs, material costs, and legal disputes.

Why the Trump administration is waging war on fraud

The Trump administration has declared a "war on fraud," prioritizing benefit scams, especially in health care, with J.D. Vance chairing an anti-scam task force and highly publicized arrests. While an estimated \$233bn-\$521bn is lost to federal fraud annually, the administration's campaign appears politically motivated, targeting "Blue

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states" and using fraud as a pretext to undermine Democratic-led programs. Critics highlight inconsistencies, such as presidential pardons for health-care fraudsters and the redirection of prosecutors from fraud cases, suggesting the initiative is primarily a messaging strategy ahead of midterm elections rather than a genuine, comprehensive effort to minimize scams.

J.D. Vance's theory of Trumpism is no match for the practice

Vice-President J.D. Vance, a "post-liberal right" intellectual and isolationist, struggles to reconcile his grand strategic theories with President Donald Trump's impulsive and often contradictory policies. Despite Vance's opposition to a war with Iran, Trump initiated it, forcing Vance to defend the conflict and act as a negotiator, abandoning his prior stances. Similarly, Vance's ideological pilgrimage to support Viktor Orban in Hungary, framed as a defense of "Western civilization," was immediately rebuked by Hungarian

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voters who overwhelmingly rejected Orban. These events expose Trumpism as an ideology-free movement centered on one man's instincts, consistently thwarting Vance's attempts to imbue it with a cohesive grand strategy.

ESSAY

War and the making of a superpower

America's entry into the first world war, propelled by Woodrow Wilson's vision for global democracy, decisively tipped the conflict's balance, despite his idealism for a League of Nations failing domestically. The war also catalyzed social changes, empowering suffragettes to secure the 19th Amendment and fostering Hollywood's rise as a purveyor of American soft power. The subsequent "Roaring Twenties" ushered in mass consumerism and financial exuberance, but ended

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abruptly with the 1929 stock market crash and the Great Depression, a crisis worsened by protectionist trade policies and tight monetary decisions.

John Maynard Keynes saved capitalism from itself

John Maynard Keynes's groundbreaking "General Theory" provided the intellectual framework for governments to counteract capitalism's inherent instability, demonstrating that intervention through public spending could alleviate deep unemployment that markets alone could not quickly fix. Franklin Roosevelt's intuitive New Deal policies, implemented before Keynes's book, pragmatically addressed the Great Depression by introducing social security, regulating banks, and creating jobs, thus entrenching a new liberal idea of state intervention in the economy. Despite ongoing ideological battles and the brief revival of "supply-side" policies, Keynesian methods proved powerfully effective in subsequent downturns like the

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Great Recession and covid-19, highlighting the government's capacity to maintain full employment.

THE AMERICAS

Rio de Janeiro is a beautiful warning to the rest of Brazil

Rio de Janeiro, though a beautiful and popular tourist destination, serves as a grim warning for Brazil due to its deep-rooted corruption and entrenched criminal influence, with all its 21st-century elected governors having been jailed or impeached. Beyond the glamorous facade of its south zone, vast favelas and working-class neighborhoods are dominated by gangs and militias, which exert control over millions and often operate with impunity. Recent arrests of high-ranking officials on suspicion of links to drug traffickers and an assassination linked to militia activities underscore the systemic

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infiltration of crime into public institutions, prompting calls for federal intervention.

ASIA

A battle for female voters is changing India's elections

The increasing political engagement of female voters is transforming Indian elections, with their turnout now slightly exceeding men's, driven by rising empowerment and literacy. Female voters are found to prioritize tangible welfare promises over culture-war issues, reflecting a "survival instinct" in a male-dominated society. This shift has led to a rapid proliferation of state-level cash-transfer schemes specifically targeting women, offering monthly payouts that improve consumption and women's agency within families. However, these programs also raise concerns about

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being vote-buying disguised as emancipation, their haphazard implementation, and the risk of crowding out crucial investments in education and health.

Singapore and Malaysia knock heads over the war in Iran

Singapore and Malaysia are clashing over their differing responses to the war in Iran, particularly regarding the freedom of navigation through critical international straits. Singapore's foreign minister emphasized adherence to international law for unimpeded passage through the Strait of Hormuz, fearing that negotiating tolls would undermine similar rights for the Strait of Malacca, which is vital to Singapore. Malaysian officials, conversely, criticized Singapore's stance as aligned with Western powers and defended Iran's actions, highlighting their non-alignment and historical geopolitical differences over regional security and Israel. This spat also serves as political maneuvering ahead of potential Malaysian elections, with standing up to

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Singapore potentially boosting domestic popularity.

Collapsing remittances will compound Asia's energy shock

The war in Iran is precipitating a collapse in remittances from the Gulf to South and South-East Asia, exacerbating the region's energy shock as millions of migrant workers are forced to return home. The significant reduction in remittances, which represent a quarter of Nepal's GDP and 6.5% of Bangladesh's, will bring severe hardship, reduce crucial investments in education, and leave many facing unemployment. While some hope for a quick resolution or new opportunities in East Asian countries like Japan and South Korea, establishing new migration routes is challenging due to existing networks in the Gulf and reluctance in new host countries to admit large numbers of foreigners.

Scam Inc has a new weapon

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Online fraudsters in South-East Asia are rapidly evolving their tactics, moving beyond traditional, labor-intensive scams to employ sophisticated spyware, turning Scam Inc into a more disruptive force. Investigators have traced spyware, likely acquired from Chinese-speaking vendors, that captures biometric data, accesses bank accounts, and compromises phone functions, allowing criminals to quickly target victims' entire networks. Operating from fortified compounds, these gangs, which force hundreds of thousands to work for them, are also experimenting with AI chatbots and deepfake voice tools, signaling a future of even more convincing and harder-to-detect cyber-crimes within the \$500bn internet fraud industry.

The secret of India's most liveable megacity

Kolkata, once the capital of British India, has transformed into India's most liveable megacity, boasting low costs of living, a vibrant cultural scene, and

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expanding public transport, largely due to Chief Minister Mamata Banerjee's modernization and welfare schemes. However, this pleasantness is a symptom of economic stagnation, as West Bengal's share of national output declines, offering few white-collar jobs and attracting minimal foreign investment compared to other Indian states. Despite its historical trade hub status and role as a magnet for migrants, Kolkata remains a chronic underachiever relative to its potential, and the upcoming state elections will determine its future trajectory.

CHINA

Why China's government worries about AI

China's government, led by President Xi Jinping, views artificial intelligence as an "epoch-defining technology" essential for economic growth and global competition, but is increasingly concerned about its risks. The rapid

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adoption of AI agents like OpenClaw highlighted vulnerabilities such as data deletion, excessive computing power consumption, and cyber defense weaknesses, leading to regulatory bans in sensitive sectors. Policymakers face a delicate balancing act: relying on private tech firms for innovation while imposing strict controls to prevent job displacement, ensure content "controllability," and address emerging security threats and public anxieties about AI's potential to replace human workers.

Training for Beijing's humanoid half-marathon is gruelling

Beijing's Yizhuang industrial-technology park will host a humanoid robot half-marathon, with over 300 robots competing alongside humans, a significant increase from last year's event. The race, which judges robots on speed, real-time decision-making, endurance, and gait, aims to stimulate innovation among China's numerous humanoid-robot makers and researchers. Teams are

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practicing nightly for the event, which offers guaranteed orders to the champion, reflecting the state's strategic intent to accelerate the development of its robotics industry and gain an edge in the global race against rivals like America.

Soaring numbers of Chinese women demand divorce

Despite government efforts to bolster marriage and birth rates, including a 30-day cooling-off period, divorces by mutual agreement in China reached a five-year high in 2025, with women initiating about 70% of court cases. This trend reflects increasing financial independence and changing attitudes among women, who prioritize the "quality of the marriage" over egregious behavior, though proving marital breakdown in court remains challenging and property division laws often favor men. The rise in divorces, coupled with a decline in marriage rates, indicates that policymakers must address gender equality within relationships to make marriage more

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attractive and durable.

China's pension failings expose its harshest inequality

Chaguan highlights China's stark pension inequality, where rural elderly, exemplified by farmers in Chongqing, are forced into arduous labor due to meager monthly payouts of 163 yuan, a fraction of what urban retirees receive. This disparity persists despite China's "victory over absolute poverty," leaving over 80% of elderly rural residents still working, a situation deemed undignified for a country promoting "common prosperity." While calls for increased rural pensions are gaining traction in parliament, the government resists significant boosts due to fears of creating a broader welfare state and fiscal constraints, prioritizing infrastructure spending over social safety nets for its aging rural population.

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MIDDLE EAST & AFRICA

The Gulf war has settled into an uneasy limbo

The Gulf war has entered an uneasy limbo, with a ceasefire in place, yet Iran's threats have kept the Strait of Hormuz largely closed, and America has imposed its own blockade on Iranian shipping. Iran's economy, already dire, faces further strain from blocked oil exports and disrupted food imports, though it claims it can endure the pressure. Peace talks in Pakistan are underway, with America prioritizing Iran's nuclear program and showing flexibility on enrichment, but a comprehensive, verifiable deal remains elusive and fraught with mistrust. Both sides are using economic and military leverage, and the global energy crisis is intensifying as foreign contractors retreat from Gulf projects.

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Donald Trump's blockade of Hormuz is a dangerous gamble

Donald Trump's imposition of a blockade on Iranian shipping in the Strait of Hormuz, enacted on April 13th, is a perilous gamble designed to economically coerce Iran where military action has failed. While America can militarily enforce the blockade, its economic and political repercussions are complex, risking further global energy price surges if the strait remains closed to other traffic and Iran retaliates. The measure also threatens to antagonize American allies like India and China, whose ships could be interdicted, and critics argue it further undermines international law, contributing to the erosion of a rules-based order.

Israel and Lebanon both want to dislodge Hizbullah

Israel and Lebanon held their first official direct talks in decades in Washington, yet Israel continued heavy

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bombardment of southern Lebanon, killing hundreds and displacing millions. Both nations share an interest in dislodging Hizbullah from Lebanon's south, but the Lebanese government faces thinly veiled coup threats from the Iranian-backed militia if it attempts to disband the group. Israeli military leaders acknowledge that fully disarming Hizbullah without occupying all of Lebanon is impossible. A lasting political deal would require a complex internal Lebanese consensus and would ultimately depend on Iran permitting the group to accept terms.

Is bombing power plants and oil facilities a war crime?

Donald Trump's threats to bomb Iranian infrastructure, such as desalination and electric-generating plants, raise questions about their legality under international laws of war. Civilian facilities are only lawful targets if they serve definite military purposes, minimize civilian harm, and the military advantage is proportionate to expected

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civilian harm; bombing essential civilian infrastructure would violate these principles. While America claims the right to attack "war-sustaining" targets like oil facilities, the indiscriminate destruction of buildings, as seen in Gaza and Lebanon, is unlawful. Trump's "puffery" might shield him legally, but his subordinates and allies could face war crime charges if they obey manifestly unlawful orders.

Zimbabwe's bizarre economic boom

Zimbabwe is experiencing an unusual economic boom driven by a gold rush and high commodity prices, which has stabilized its currency and led to its lowest inflation in 30 years. The country recorded its highest official gold production in 2025, generating significant export revenue and spurring economic activity, including a thriving black market and property sales. Despite this economic improvement, President Emmerson Mnangagwa, 83, is pursuing constitutional amendments to extend his rule, solidifying power through patronage

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and hindering hopes for normalized relations and official development finance from the West.

A landslide victory in Benin's presidential election was hardly democratic

Benin, once a bastion of multi-party democracy in West Africa, witnessed a highly undemocratic presidential election where Romuald Wadagni secured 94% of the vote as the chosen successor of outgoing President Patrice Talon. Talon's ten-year tenure combined economic growth?Benin achieved 7.5% GDP growth in 2024?with a stark authoritarian shift, implementing electoral and constitutional reforms that entrenched his ruling alliance and suppressed opposition parties. Wadagni's victory means Talon will maintain significant influence, while human rights have been curtailed and courts muted, yet observers in the region have largely overlooked the democratic decline, prioritizing security concerns amidst regional jihadist conflicts.

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EUROPE

?Complete change of regime? in Hungary

Peter Magyar's centrist Tisza party achieved a crushing victory in Hungary's election, ousting Viktor Orban after 16 years and ushering in what Magyar promised would be a "complete change of regime" to eradicate systemic corruption and restore rule of law. Magyar plans to dismantle Orban's "System of National Co-operation," reform the constitution, and quickly unlock ?18bn in blocked EU funds, signaling a constructive approach with Brussels and a reversal of Orban's veto on aid for Ukraine. Orban's defeat is a significant relief for the EU and a blow to his MAGA allies, as his governing machine is already showing cracks and loyalists may reveal details of past corruption.

A scramble ahead of France?s presidential election

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With France's presidential election 12 months away, the populist-right National Rally is almost certain to reach the run-off, while mainstream parties are in a "worst rivalry" scramble to unite behind a single candidate. The crowded field of aspirants across the left, right, and center risks splitting the vote, potentially leaving voters with a choice between two extremes. While Edouard Philippe currently appears to be the only candidate capable of challenging the National Rally's Jordan Bardella in a run-off, decisive polling trends often emerge much closer to the election, making the outcome highly uncertain.

In the Gulf, Ukraine flaunts its skill at intercepting drones

Ukraine has emerged as a formidable defense-industry power, forging ten-year security partnerships with Saudi Arabia, Qatar, and the UAE in the Gulf, where its battle-tested drone defense expertise is in high demand. Having honed mass production of cost-effective

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interceptors and developed AI-enabled battlefield management systems, Ukraine can effectively counter cheap Iranian Shahed drones, far surpassing the capabilities offered by America and Europe. These agreements provide Ukraine with crucial financial injections and new orders, strengthening its geopolitical standing and enabling it to export its protection system and military knowledge globally, even as it sources dual-use parts from China.

European policymakers fiddle with energy prices, again

European policymakers are once again subsidizing fuel costs, echoing past mistakes, in response to protests and high energy prices caused by the Gulf war, with countries like Ireland, Spain, and Poland introducing tax cuts. This approach is economically questionable as petrol prices are not historically high in real terms, and fuel comprises a small portion of overall inflation. Critically, these price caps perversely subsidize demand,

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exacerbating Europe's reliance on imported diesel and kerosene, thereby delaying necessary demand adjustments that would otherwise occur as Gulf supplies remain impeded.

Where should Pablo Picasso's "Guernica" be allowed to hang?

A Spanish-Basque dispute has erupted over whether Pablo Picasso's iconic "Guernica" should temporarily move from Madrid's Reina Sofía museum to Bilbao's Guggenheim, marking the 90th anniversaries of the Basque government and the bombing of Guernica. Basque nationalists demand the move, but the Reina Sofía, backed by the Socialist government, argues the painting is too fragile to travel. This row, supported by Catalonia's Socialist regional government despite its own similar art repatriation issues, underscores a deeper, politically charged question about how a radically decentralized Spain manages its national art collections and whether art is destined to be localized.

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Orban-proofing the EU

Viktor Orban's election defeat in Hungary has brought a resounding victory for moderation in Europe, offering hope for reversing democratic decay and improving EU relations, yet it raises awkward questions for the bloc. Orban's 16-year rule, marked by authoritarianism, corruption, and obstruction within the EU, highlighted the bloc's challenges in containing backsliding members. His success in consolidating power and becoming an icon for populist conservatives was fueled by his ability to tap into political moods and exploit EU subsidies, but was ultimately undone by voter fatigue and the belated conditioning of financial aid from Brussels. While his departure is a relief, the fundamental problem of managing democratic backsliding within the EU remains unresolved, and the bloc faces ongoing, pressing challenges beyond Orban's influence.

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BRITAIN

Reform UK is reassembling Boris Johnson's electoral coalition

Nigel Farage's Reform UK is successfully reassembling an electoral coalition remarkably similar to Boris Johnson's 2019 Conservative base, drawing significant support from disaffected voters. Polling at around 25%, Reform's supporters are typically less educated, middle-aged or older, white, and largely voted for Brexit, motivated by exasperation with the Conservative government's failures on immigration and public services. While a core group holds radical and pro-Trump views, a larger segment desires stability and practical solutions, viewing Reform as a new alternative after disappointments with both Conservatives and Labour. Farage faces the challenge of satisfying this diverse base while navigating his own radical tendencies and past missteps, which could alienate his new

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supporters.

Britons are more politically promiscuous than ever

Britain's political landscape is increasingly fragmented, with the traditional Conservative and Labour duopoly waning, as voters exhibit unprecedented political promiscuity. A model by The Economist, using data from More In Common, reveals that over the past two years, more voters have switched parties than ever before, with Labour's support rapidly declining since the 2024 general election. This shift has significantly benefited the populist-left Greens and populist-right Reform UK, altering voter demographics and making traditional campaign targeting more challenging. The diminished predictive power of long-held voter characteristics like age and ethnicity signals a volatile "swingtime era" where a large portion of the electorate lacks strong party loyalty.

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New legislation will restrict Reform UK's biggest source of money

Reform UK, despite leading in national polls, faces a significant challenge to its funding as new Labour government legislation targets its primary income sources. In 2025, Reform UK received more large donations than any other British party, accumulating over £18.6m, largely thanks to a £12m contribution from a single crypto billionaire, Christopher Harborne. The proposed Representation of the People Bill aims to impose a moratorium on crypto donations and a £100,000 cap on donations from British citizens living abroad. These measures, while not explicitly targeting Reform, will drastically reduce its ability to receive large foreign-based contributions, forcing the party to adapt its fundraising strategy.

Labour will struggle to placate Britain's angry graduates

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Britain's Plan 2 student loan system has ignited widespread discontent among graduates, who are burdened by high debts, accumulating interest, and repeated, retroactive changes to repayment terms by successive governments. Graduates leaving university in 2025 face average debts of £53,000, significantly higher than in other wealthy nations, with many seeing their loan balances grow despite making regular payments. Labour's proposed stopgap measure of capping interest rates for 12 months is unlikely to satisfy calls for sweeping reforms, as deeper changes to interest rates or repayment thresholds would cost billions and predominantly benefit higher earners. The current system, where public money now covers only 3% of costs for recent cohorts, has eroded goodwill and risks hardening frustrations into costly demands for debt forgiveness.

Does Britain send too many people to university?

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A renewed debate in Britain questions whether too many students are pursuing university degrees, fueled by concerns over student debt and the value of certain courses. Despite tuition fee hikes in 2012, university participation continued to climb, with nearly 60% of young Britons now holding post-secondary qualifications. However, critics highlight that over 10% of new undergraduates lack A-levels, leading to high dropout rates, and studies suggest about one-fifth of graduates would be financially better off not attending university, particularly those in creative arts. The Conservative Party proposes cutting 100,000 university places annually, citing the high cost to taxpayers from debt write-offs for "low value" degrees, though this alarms those who warn of choking off vital labor supplies.

The invention of Wales

The idea of an independent Wales, once considered outlandish, is gaining significant traction, with support

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now comparable to Scotland's pre-referendum levels, and Plaid Cymru expected to become the largest party in the Senedd. Unlike Scotland's historical statehood, Welsh independence would be an act of "institutional invention," given its relatively modern symbols of statehood and limited devolved powers. The surge in support is attributed to the "Brexit jolt" to Welsh identity and the Covid-19 pandemic, which provided a taste of national autonomy. Despite historical Welsh reluctance and Westminster's neglect, a "centrifugal period" in British politics is slowly transforming this once-literary dream into a peculiar reality, potentially leading to the breakup of Britain.

INTERNATIONAL

**The game theory behind violating
ceasefires**

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Ceasefires, such as the one between America and Iran, often begin with violations, but these transgressions do not necessarily derail negotiations and can instead function as a form of "strategic bargaining." Data from numerous Middle East ceasefires since 2020 show that while violence decreases significantly, it rarely ceases entirely, with sides often engaging in "tit-for-tat" exchanges to gain leverage at the negotiating table. Iran, particularly through its proxy Hizbullah, has historically used these "deterrence equations" in lower-intensity conflicts to restrain stronger adversaries without escalating to full-scale war. This suggests that violations during the Iran ceasefire might be deliberate acts to reset deterrence and influence talks, with all sides calculating acceptable thresholds of aggression.

Millions will go hungry if the Strait of Hormuz stays closed

The ongoing closure of the Strait of Hormuz, intensified by America's own blockade, is driving up global prices

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for oil, natural gas, and fertilizer, threatening a "slow-motion famine machine" that could push an additional 45 million people into hunger. The Gulf region is a critical source for 30-35% of global urea and ammonia, and disruptions during planting season will significantly reduce harvests, leading to soaring food prices, especially for poorer farmers. This impending crisis is exacerbated by an anticipated powerful El Niño and cuts in humanitarian aid budgets, meaning that without a swift reopening of the strait, global food price inflation could reach 12-18% by year-end, with disproportionately severe impacts on vulnerable populations.

If it starts, a nuclear-arms race will be unstoppable

Rafael Mariano Grossi, Director-General of the International Atomic Energy Agency, gravely warns that the world stands on the brink of an unstoppable nuclear-arms race, with many countries privately

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debating acquiring nuclear weapons. He emphasizes that the existing non-proliferation regime, despite past failures, is a crucial point of stability, and its breakdown would inevitably trigger a domino effect of proliferation. Grossi attributes Iran's current crisis to its "nuclear bluffing" and ambiguity, asserting that force is not a cure-all as knowledge cannot be unlearned, making a negotiated settlement the only viable solution. However, some cynically point to the survival of leaders like Kim Jong Un, who defied the world to build nukes, as a counter-argument, suggesting that in a "lonely world," nuclear arms may be perceived as the ultimate security guarantee.

BUSINESS

Could AI's leading men become as powerful as Ford or Rockefeller?

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The five leading men in artificial intelligence?Dario Amodei, Demis Hassabis, Elon Musk, Mark Zuckerberg, and Sam Altman?wield immense power over a transformative technology, yet their current influence pales compared to historical titans like Henry Ford or John D. Rockefeller. The Economist's analysis of 11 technological waves over 150 years ranks Henry Ford as the most powerful mogul, based on wealth, workforce size, and corporate control, highlighting his profound societal impact. While AI is in its infancy and its magnates' power may grow, they currently employ fewer people and exert less corporate control than their industrial predecessors. However, history suggests that capitalism's most significant phases are often driven by towering, quasi-autocratic figures, implying that a new Rockefeller or Ford could still emerge from the AI industry.

Why Anthropic and OpenAI are locking up their latest models

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Anthropic and OpenAI are restricting access to their cutting-edge AI models, such as Mythos and GPT 5.4 Cyber, to a select group of vetted companies, creating both marketing buzz and policy concern. This staggered release strategy serves multiple commercial interests beyond safety: it helps prevent "industrial-scale" distillation by rival labs and manages a shortfall in computing power by onboarding customers only as capacity permits. Furthermore, limiting access to advanced AI systems conveniently shifts power back to the model-makers, making it harder for developers to create applications compatible with inaccessible models. This trend suggests leading AI labs will continue to exert significant control over who accesses their technology, potentially frustrating those excluded.

America?s corporate boards are under siege

America's corporate boards are experiencing a turbulent "Wild West" proxy season, facing unprecedented

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pressure from activist shareholders and regulatory changes that undermine their traditional control. Last year marked a record for shareholder activism, with demands for board shake-ups becoming increasingly successful due to regulatory shifts allowing shareholders more choice in director selection. Compounding this, the Trump administration is scrutinizing proxy advisers for promoting "radical agendas," and new SEC guidance discourages passive investors from over-communicating with boards. These combined pressures are depriving boards of crucial information and flexibility, leading to heightened drama and uncertainty at annual meetings.

Australia's startup scene is thriving at last

Australia's startup ecosystem is flourishing, with venture capital funding exceeding \$5bn last year and the country boasting a higher unicorn-to-VC investment ratio than any other. This momentum is fueled by a maturing generation of successful tech firms like Atlassian and Canva, whose alumni are now founding their own

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ventures, creating a vibrant network of local VC investors. Additionally, Australia benefits from world-class computer science universities and a "boomerang effect" of talent returning from Silicon Valley, combined with a tech-savvy government and a population open to adopting new technologies. Despite its small market size and challenges like stringent superannuation fund rules, Australia's tech sector shows strong potential, though it faces recent high-profile lay-offs and a limited early-stage funding landscape.

India's space industry is blasting off

India's space industry is experiencing a commercial boom, with the Indian Space Research Organisation (ISRO) aiming for its first crewed space flight next year, thanks to three pivotal figures. Jawaharlal Nehru's early commitment to science laid the foundation for ISRO in 1962, focusing on development goals. Narendra Modi's government further propelled the sector by liberalizing it in 2020, creating IN-SPACe to grant licenses and access

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to ISRO's capacity, leading to over 400 startups and \$8bn in private revenue. Finally, Elon Musk's SpaceX has drastically reduced satellite launch costs, inspiring Indian tycoons like AgniKul Cosmos and attracting investment, as the industry increasingly serves defense and aims for advanced manufacturing.

The desperate pursuit of final approval

Bartleby's office parable humorously depicts the agonizing process of seeking "final approval" for a new product user survey, which quickly spirals out of control. Initially intended to be concise, the survey rapidly expands as executive leadership members, despite prior opportunities, introduce numerous new questions and stylistic demands, reflecting a lack of discipline. The protagonist's frustration boils over in a misdirected email, highlighting the communication breakdowns and power dynamics inherent in corporate approval processes. Ultimately, the CEO's eleventh-hour intervention to add AI questions while deleting existing

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ones about the core product underscores the arbitrary nature of such decisions.

From Ralph Lauren to The Row, American luxury is booming

While the global personal luxury goods market has contracted for two consecutive years, American luxury labels like Ralph Lauren, Coach, and The Row are experiencing a notable boom. Ralph Lauren and Coach have seen significant revenue and share price increases, driven by strategic turnarounds, product refreshes, greater control over distribution, and targeted marketing campaigns that resonate with younger shoppers. This success is also bolstered by resilient American consumer spending, a strengthening euro making European brands more expensive, and American brands generally offering more accessible price points while also catering to the high-end "quiet luxury" segment. Though Europe still dominates fashion shows and some American brands struggle, the industry's old assumption that only Europe

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can do luxury is increasingly being challenged.

David Zaslav and the tyranny of incentives

David Zaslav, CEO of Warner Bros Discovery, stands to receive over \$800m in compensation if Paramount Skydance's takeover of Warner Bros Discovery is approved, a payout that epitomizes the "tyranny of incentives" in corporate America. This mega-payout, comprising severance and generous stock awards, highlights how executive compensation can diverge from shareholder interests, especially given the unfulfilled promises and precarious debt of an earlier merger Zaslav orchestrated. Despite shareholder disapproval of his past compensation, such "say on pay" votes are non-binding. The deal, though creating an entertainment giant, raises questions about the accountability of boards in structuring such lucrative exit packages.

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FINANCE & ECONOMICS

War will drain the Gulf's \$6trn treasure chest

The Gulf Cooperation Council's (GCC) \$6trn sovereign-wealth funds face significant drains due to the war in Iran, complicating their global investment strategies and long-term diversification goals. Iranian retaliatory strikes have caused billions in infrastructure damage, requiring costly rebuilding and new pipelines to bypass the Strait of Hormuz, along with increased defense spending. These funds, which have made substantial illiquid investments in AI, private credit, and property, will likely be pressured to cover these domestic costs, potentially forcing sales at a loss and diverting attention from future-oriented bets. The conflict also diminishes the region's appeal for foreign investment and jeopardizes ambitious national projects, leading to inevitable write-downs for funds like Saudi Arabia's PIF.

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America's next Fed chair is caught in a vice

Kevin Warsh, the likely next Fed chair, faces a difficult environment, caught between Donald Trump's demands for interest rate cuts and rising inflationary pressures exacerbated by the war in Iran. The conflict has pushed headline inflation to 3.3% in March, and the energy shock is expected to impact other prices, making monetary stimulus unwarranted. Warsh's argument that AI-driven productivity justifies lower rates is challenged by senior Fed officials, who suggest AI investment could raise inflation and the neutral rate. Furthermore, Jerome Powell's decision to remain on the Fed board, potentially even as chairman pro tempore, and Trump's vow to sack him, add political volatility and complexity to Warsh's impending confirmation.

Pakistan's deft diplomacy is an economic blessing. And a curse

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Pakistan's adept diplomacy during the Gulf war, acting as a mediator between Donald Trump and Iran, provides crucial short-term financial breathing room but ultimately perpetuates a cycle of delayed economic reforms. The country faces severe economic strain from rising fuel and food prices, the closure of the Strait of Hormuz, and collapsing remittances from its Gulf-based diaspora, threatening its foreign-exchange reserves. Despite a history of numerous IMF bail-outs and significant foreign aid from allies, Pakistan's "strategic rents" enable its military-dominated economy to avoid necessary structural changes, leaving its citizens economically behind those in India and Bangladesh. The country's geopolitical value repeatedly offers escape routes from crises, preventing the implementation of reforms needed for sustainable growth.

The tech jobs bust is real. Don't blame AI (yet)

The current tech jobs bust, marked by significant layoffs

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at major American tech firms and a decline in tech's share of overall employment, is real but not primarily attributable to artificial intelligence yet. While AI enthusiasts link job cuts to the technology's growing capabilities, early AI tools were primitive, and widespread adoption remains low, with surveys showing minimal impact on employment. Instead, the downturn is largely driven by a post-pandemic hiring binge, rising interest rates since 2022, increased outsourcing to foreign IT consultancies, and a broader dispersion of tech skills into non-tech sectors like retail and construction. Tech jobs are not disappearing but are spreading throughout the economy, shifting career paths for young coders beyond traditional tech giants.

How to build a portfolio when bonds fail to buffer stocks

The traditional 60/40 portfolio allocation, which relies on bonds acting as a buffer against stock market declines, is being challenged as the correlation between

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stocks and government bonds has turned reliably positive since 2022. During energy shocks, both asset classes tend to move in tandem, diminishing the diversification benefits that investors have long exploited. However, abandoning stock-bond splits is not recommended due to a lack of viable alternatives that offer similar long-run returns and diversification. Instead, investors should reassess portfolio weights, with risk-averse individuals increasing bond allocations and daredevils increasing stocks, acknowledging that bonds now provide a thinner buffer for equity risk.

Global imbalances are back. Who's to blame?

Global imbalances, characterized by large current-account surpluses and deficits, have returned, igniting renewed debate over their causes, reminiscent of discussions before the 2008 financial crisis. America's large budget deficit is cited as a contributor, as fiscal easing increases consumption and strengthens the dollar,

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widening its trade deficit. China's industrial policy, while boosting exports, does not reliably lead to overall trade surpluses unless coupled with "consumption suppression," which in its current form is an unintended consequence of a property slump. Ultimately, the causes are complex and multifaceted, implicating several factors and leading to a global economic situation that, while not as large as two decades ago, remains concerning.

SCIENCE & TECHNOLOGY

How AI hackers will shake up cyber-security

Anthropic's announcement of its AI model Mythos, capable of finding and exploiting software vulnerabilities, has generated both excitement and concern, prompting the firm to limit its release to an exclusive group of companies under Project Glasswing.

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This move, along with OpenAI's similar GPT 5.4 Cyber, aims to help critical infrastructure organizations strengthen their defenses before such powerful models become widely available for nefarious purposes. While security researchers are cautiously optimistic that AI will eventually benefit defenders by enabling more thorough software checks, the short-term future is anticipated to be chaotic due to the cost of AI checking and the prevalence of unmaintained software. The core challenge is whether attackers can exploit vulnerabilities faster than defenders can fix them.

How to make buffet breakfasts less wasteful

Researchers in Norway and Italy have developed a virtual breakfast buffet model to devise strategies for reducing food waste, a common problem at hotel buffets where diners often take more than they can eat. The model, which simulates guest motivations and external factors, found that a diner's attitude towards

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sustainability and social conformity are the most influential factors in limiting waste. Plate size emerged as the most significant external driver, with smaller plates encouraging diners to finish their food, while buffet duration and food diversity had less impact. Hotels can leverage this tool to optimize food layouts, plate sizes, and even messaging to minimize waste and associated costs.

Tumour cells use a genetic trick to become drug-resistant

Tumor cells employ a newly discovered genetic trick by forming tiny, circular extra-chromosomal DNA (ecDNA) bodies, allowing them to bypass Mendel's laws of inheritance and evolve drug resistance at a surprisingly rapid rate. These ecDNA fragments, often containing defense mechanisms, can rapidly replicate and re-integrate into chromosomes with the help of specific anchor proteins and DNA sequences, increasing the chances of harmful new traits emerging faster than

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conventional mutations. Researchers believe these anchor proteins and DNA sequences are prime targets for future cancer treatments, as disabling them could strip tumor cells of this evolutionary advantage, although other factors also contribute to ecDNA appearance.

How natural selection really shaped humanity

A new study published in *Nature* reveals that strong directional selection, where advantageous genetic mutations rapidly spread, played a far more pervasive role in human evolution than previously understood. Geneticists from Harvard University used a novel statistical toolkit on a doubled dataset of over 15,000 ancient West Eurasian genomes spanning 18,000 years. Their analysis identified 479 gene variants likely resulting from natural selection in the past 11,000 years, significantly expanding the known instances and challenging existing hypotheses about specific adaptations like coeliac disease susceptibility and cystic

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fibrosis. This suggests that adaptation to evolutionary pressures dramatically intensified during the Holocene, likely driven by lifestyle changes such as the rise of agriculture.

Are sugar substitutes healthier than the real thing?

Despite claims of aiding weight loss and preventing tooth decay, a growing body of research suggests sugar substitutes may have unexpected and detrimental health consequences, prompting a precautionary advisory from the World Health Organization. While some short-term trials show reduced weight gain with substitutes, larger, long-term observational studies link higher consumption to increased weight, heart problems, diabetes, and cancer. Hypotheses for this harm include the activation of metabolic signaling mechanisms similar to sugar, effects on immune cells, and alterations to gut bacteria. Avoiding these ubiquitous sweeteners is challenging, as they are commonly used in processed foods, making fruit

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the most prudent choice for satisfying sweet cravings.

CULTURE

Mary Beard offers a spirited defence of studying classics

Mary Beard's "Talking Classics" provides a spirited and provocative defense of studying classics, discarding traditional arguments to instead highlight its unique capacity for exploring historical similarities and differences. Beard contends that classical literature's enduring relevance lies in its ability to pose fundamental questions, encouraging debate rather than offering simple answers, and serving as a valuable laboratory for discussing contentious issues from a helpful distance. She argues that the historical misuse of classical history by imperialists or fascists should be viewed as an asset for understanding themes like tyranny and colonialism,

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rather than a reason to abandon the discipline, advocating for its study as a means to challenge and critically engage with both ancient and modern worlds.

What the world's most hated avian reveals about people

Gordon McMullan's "Cormorant" delves into the cultural history of the much-maligned bird, arguing that its bestial reputation is largely a reflection of human greed and prejudice rather than its true nature. The book reveals how the cormorant's dark plumage, awkward posture, and literary portrayals (like the Devil in Milton's "Paradise Lost") have cemented its negative image, despite evidence showing it is no more greedy or invasive than other fish-eating birds. McMullan's work thus offers a perceptive "cultural history of greed and prejudice," exploring how humans project moral judgments onto nature and revealing more about human biases than about the cormorant itself.

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Liberalism must revive itself before it's too late

Adrian Wooldridge's "Centrists of the World Unite!" argues that liberalism, the philosophy that forged the modern world, is in crisis and must urgently revive its core principles of individualism, constrained power, and open discussion to avoid "illiberal anarchy." He critiques contemporary liberals for splintering into factions that betray these ideals, such as left-wingers abandoning meritocracy and market fundamentalists prioritizing narrow freedoms. Wooldridge prescribes a renewal that involves moving "simultaneously to the left and the right"—cracking down on corporate rent-seeking and embracing excellence and the "civilizing role of authority"—while taking populist concerns seriously to reclaim the political center.

Western men are going abroad to find traditional wives

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A growing phenomenon of "passport bros" sees Western men, disillusioned with modern dating, traveling abroad?particularly to Thailand, Brazil, Colombia, the Philippines, and Vietnam?in search of what they perceive as more "feminine" and "traditional" wives. Enabled by remote work and digital nomad visas, these men document their relationships online, often showcasing partners who cater to them in ways they feel are lacking in Western women. Critics highlight the potential for exploitation and the role of income disparities in these relationships, where foreign partners may gain financial security. However, the trend reflects a broader cultural shift among some young men seeking compliant partners and more traditional gender roles.

A rom-com ignites a row about tragedy, taste and art

"The Drama," a controversial rom-com featuring a school shooting plan, has ignited debate about artistic taste and the depiction of tragedy, with critics lambasting

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its queasy humor. While ambitious artists often tackle painful subjects, and satire can be serious, critics argue the film's superficial engagement with gun violence and its shifting focus undermine its artistic intent. The narrative, which explores themes of forgiveness and the unknowability of others through a couple's confessions, is ultimately seen as carelessly looking away from the profound horror it initially evokes, failing to sustain the necessary gravitas despite some worthwhile barbs about American exceptionalism.

The dark side of posting about your children online

Fortesa Latifi's "Like, Follow, Subscribe" exposes the exploitative dark side of "kidfluencing," a multi-billion-dollar industry where parents monetize their children's lives by sharing intimate details online for social media views and sponsored content. Latifi details how parents act as "producers," incentivizing children to film every milestone, even painful or private

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moments, for lucrative brand deals. The industry lacks the legal protections of child acting, raising concerns about children's consent, labor hours, and the psychological impact of growing up with their childhood "plastered all over the internet," making them vulnerable to online predators and family vlogging's darker consequences.

ECONOMIC & FINANCIAL INDICATORS

Economic data, commodities and markets

No significant coverage this issue.

OBITUARY

Nick Pope investigated UFOs for the Ministry of Defence

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Nick Pope, a civil servant known as "Spooky" for investigating UFOs for Britain's Ministry of Defence (MoD) from 1991, has died at 60. Though 80% of sightings were explicable, 5% defied explanation, leading him to believe in genuine Unidentified Aerial Phenomena (UAPs). Despite his MoD role being deemed "nonsense" and his desk shut down in 2009, he became a celebrity commentator and serious advocate for investigating UAPs, challenging authorities to address what he considered one of humanity's most profound questions.